I've always had a love of dogs, despite not having one as a child, and chose my boarding house at Bedford because it had one that I could walk before and after school. Farm work gives me a different element of identity, I suppose. In the early days, I played cricket, went to the gym, had a coffee and killed time. We all go through certain stages of life, don't we? There have been times when I've craved the release of going back to the farm. It has always given me a sense of peace.

Occasionally, the formalities of cricket get you down. My pet hate as England captain was the group press conference. It was part and parcel of the job, a couple of times a week, before and after matches. I felt sorry for the journalists, to be honest. There were fifty or sixty of them in the room, and they knew you didn't really want to be there. You knew the topic they wanted to pursue, and the phrases or thoughts that would produce the headlines they required.

In that situation, usually near the end of the allotted time, questions tended to run into each other or, at best, be variations on a theme. It wasn't intimidating. It was more boring than anything. Of course, the game needs the media, which provides a platform from which to engage the public, but the process helps no one. My shield went up; from behind it I tossed out anodyne comments and plastic answers. One-to-one interviews, though rarer, were more satisfying since I was able to provide context and insight.

I relished the sanctuary of the farm, the absence of pressure to respond to specific agendas, but that sometimes involved an element of bluff and self-deception.

Alice and I both live a life of contrasts. Alice could, for example, spend a day in the lambing shed, wearing old clothes covered with all manner of muck, then be transformed into a dinner guest, in all her finery, at London's Landmark or Langham Hotel. We would laugh at the contrast and enjoy the variety of our lives.

I loved the fact that I wasn't consumed by cricket. I was obsessed with its mechanics and mental challenges, but it didn't completely define me. Though you don't reach the highest levels as an athlete without having the drive to run before dawn, or practise until your head and hands hurt, it helps to be able to forget your sport.

It is tempting to check the app, or even try to listen to *Test Match Special* on headphones when you're on the tractor, but switching off is not a sin. There were times when, not having been selected for a limited-overs